

S01-02 - The Overturned Vendor Cart

Player read-aloud

A vendor cart lies sideways across the road. Produce and invoices spill into the mud. A polished placard blinks: INCIDENT RESPONSE EXPECTED WITHIN 3?5 BUSINESS DAYS.

Scene summary

The party finds a vendor cart blocking the road, with spilled produce, invoices, and a useless incident placard.

Visible choices

- Investigate the cart
- Move the cart
- Call out into the woods
- Approach the body

Player questions

- What detail in The Overturned Vendor Cart tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- What cheerful warning sign did your character dismiss as marketing copy before realizing it was true?

GM notes

- The placard can be a standard route-monitoring glyph, not proof that anyone meaningfully knows what happened.
- Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it.
- Sablewood route lore: this is an approved path, and the body/cart disruption should feel like a coverage failure as much as a wilderness event.
- Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- [KEEP/EARNED] The driver died from a cut throat; the strixwolf did not kill him. (Instinct or Knowledge Medium 15)
- [ADD/EARNED] Near the cart is a pre-written Grail "Hazard Confirmed: Strixwolf Attack" tag. (Finesse or Instinct Medium 15)

Checks and rolls

- Instinct or Knowledge Separate animal scavenging from staged violence. Standard The PCs learn Tamsin was likely killed by humanoids. 15 Cleanly resolve: Separate animal scavenging from staged violence. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved

position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to The Overturned Vendor Cart. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to separate true evidence from a tempting false read, or put the carriage/cargo under time pressure. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.

Clues

- Route Ledger The delivery was delayed. Someone manipulated the logistics trail. The ledger's time marks do not match the official route.
- Bramble Strand Someone else was here. Bramble Union scouts marked the site. A tied plant-fiber marker under the cart.
- Earned seed Available if players investigate, show mercy, or ask the right question. The driver died from a cut throat; the strixwolf did not kill him. Instinct or Knowledge Medium 15
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Loot

- Use Vendor Cart and Tamsin Vell search tables
- Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out.
- Incident Response Placard?: A flat brass disc on a post holds a watchful glyph and a single cheerful bell. When trouble happens nearby, the glyph lights, the bell rings once, brightly, and then nothing else happens at all.
- Sableblade: Growing straight up out of dark forest soil, like a sapling that decided to be a sword, is a blade of living dark wood and pale metal. It has no maker's mark and hums when your hand nears the hilt.
- Recall Stone: A smooth grey pebble feels warm and ordinary until it refuses to stay where you put it. Set it down, look away, and it waits back in your palm.
- Goldwater Liability Token?: A heavy brass chit with a smiling coin-face drops into your palm like a tiny verdict. The fine print is too small to read without feeling blamed.
- Tamsin's Home-Token: A small thumb-polished token on a cord hangs beside the torn blue scarf, warm from wear and etched with a tiny house mark instead of a company seal.
- Cracked Pocket Ward?: A cheap little ward charm sits cracked down the middle, still trying to glow through a smiling warranty sticker.

Mechanics

- Plot So Far: The party is in Act One pressure: The party finds a vendor cart

- blocking the road, with spilled produce, invoices, and a useless incident placard.
- Mechanics In Play: Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
- Roll Cards: s01-02-search-tamsin-vell S01-02 Search Tamsin Vell Search Tamsin Vell Instinct Knowledge Instinct Knowledge 12 Instinct notices wounds and threat posture; Knowledge reconstructs the scene. A false monster-read hides the murder. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. A false monster-read hides the murder. Use a hard complication, lost time...
- Gm Fear Spends: Make the safe road feel less safe: noise, scent, cracked wheel, or cargo hum. Separate evidence from assumption so a monster read is tempting but incomplete.
- Conditions Hazards: Hidden
- Search Loot Clues: Search Tamsin Vell / Vendor Cart: Pocket Ward, manifest, Goldwater slip, route ledger, lived-in details.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Escalation: Escalate by making cost visible: time, noise, trust, ward instability, or someone vulnerable in danger.
- Deescalation: De-escalate through respect, care, honest testimony, useful evidence, or a concrete concession.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: The Overturned Vendor Cart asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Finesse, Instinct, Knowledge. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Class Community Ancestry Reveals: Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or wardcraft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

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